
Laís Lautenschlager Rodrigues, Ph.D.



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[Personal website](#)



[LinkedIn](#)



Rio Claro, São Paulo, Brazil

Portuguese – *Native*



English – *Fluent*

Spanish – *Beginner*

Ecologist with expertise in tropical forest ecosystems and species interactions. PhD in *Biology*, University of Miami (2025). Proficient in field data collection, geospatial and statistical analyses (ArcGIS Pro and R), wildlife monitoring via camera traps, and molecular techniques (eDNA). Research focuses on the ecological roles of medium- and large-sized mammals in tropical forests, with an emphasis on anthropogenic impacts on species diversity and conservation in Neotropical landscapes. Author of 16 peer-reviewed publications in high-impact journals.

Additional credentials include an Academic Certificate in *Geospatial Technology* from the Department of Geography at the University of Miami (2025), with demonstrated proficiency in Geographic Information Systems (GIS), remote sensing, geospatial data management, thematic cartography, and applied spatial analysis. Skilled in raster and vector data integration, spatial modeling, surface analysis, and multicriteria evaluation for ecological and environmental research using ArcGIS Pro. Experienced university educator with a record of delivering theoretical and practical instruction, leading field training, mentoring students, and providing multidisciplinary academic support across undergraduate and graduate programs.



PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Professional Consultant

2026

Lowland Tapir Conservation Initiative (LTCI/INCAB-IPÊ) (Brazil)

Camera-trap *photo-identification* of Lowland tapir individuals across three study sites in Brazil.

Professional Consultant

2025 – 2026

World Animal Protection (Brazil)

Produced a technical report and *policy brief* on integrating fauna into restoration projects in Brazil.

Teaching Assistantship

2023 – 2025

University of Miami, Miami, FL (USA)

Taught different undergraduate courses in the Department of Biology and Latin American Studies.

Independent Consultant

2017 – 2020

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP (Brazil)

Fieldwork technician (graduate students); Managed and analyzed camera trap datasets (photo and video sorting), taxonomic identification of recorded species.



EDUCATION

University of Miami (UM), Department of Biology, Miami, FL, USA

2020 – 2025

Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Biology – PI: Dr. Kenneth Feeley

Project: “*Dietary Ecological Functioning of a Large Herbivore in a Tropical Forest*”

São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Department of Ecology, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Master of Science (MS) degree in Ecology and Biodiversity – PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti Project: “ <i>Effects of Domestic Livestock and Landscape on the Diversity of Mammals in the Atlantic Forest Remnants</i> ”	2017 – 2019
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Department of Ecology, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Bachelor of Science (BS) degree in Ecology – PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti Project: “ <i>Frugivory and Seed Dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise (Chelonoidis carbonaria)</i> ”	2012 – 2016



COMPLEMENTARY EDUCATION

São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in Data Management and Analysis – R software	2026
Geospatial Technology – Certificate obtained by the Department of Geography, University of Miami Geographic Information Systems (GIS) and satellite Remote Sensing – ArcGIS Pro software	2025
R-Ladies Belo Horizonte – Online Course, Belo Horizonte, MG, Brazil Short-term course in Data Analysis with Tidyverse – R software	2022
Florestal Package – Online Course, São Paulo, Brazil Short-term course in Introduction to Geospatial Data – R software	2021
Federal University of Rio Grande do Sul (UFRGS) , Porto Alegre, RS, Brazil Short-term course in Introduction to Hierarchical Models in Ecology – R software	2019
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in Introduction to R: data management, visualization, and analysis – R software	2019
Geoprocessing without borders , Rio de Janeiro, RJ, Brazil Short-term course about GIS in the analysis of environmental risks – ArcGIS Desktop software	2017
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in <i>Scientific Photography</i>	2016
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in <i>Ornithology Studies</i>	2015
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in <i>Herpetology Studies</i>	2014
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in <i>Ecology and Seed Dispersal of Bats</i>	2014
São Paulo State University (UNESP) , Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Short-term course in <i>Introduction to Bird Ecology</i>	2012



ACADEMIC OUTPUT

▪ [Publications](#)

16. **Lautenschlager, L.**, Vieira Veloso, M. E., Souza, Y., Ribeiro, L. G., Melo-Dias, M., Montoya, S., ... & Feeley, K. J. (2026). NeoUngulatesDiet: A database of ungulate diets in the Neotropics. *Ecology*, 107(8), e70389.(2026). [10.1002/ecy.70389](https://doi.org/10.1002/ecy.70389)
15. **Lautenschlager, L.**, Souza, Y., Genes, L., Saranholi, B. H., Cristina Gestich, C. C., Motta, C. I., ... & Feeley, K. J. (2026). Unveiling the Dietary Selection of Lowland Tapirs (*Tapirus terrestris*) in a Tropical Rainforest. *Ecology and Evolution*, 16(3), e73161. [10.1002/ece3.73161](https://doi.org/10.1002/ece3.73161)

14. Regolin, A. L., Collevatti, R. G., Bailey, L. L., Boscolo, D., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Beca, G., Dias, V. B., Galetti, M. (2025). Habitat fragmentation explains the occupancy probability of the largest herbivore in the Neotropical forests. *Biological Conservation*, 311, 111413. [10.1016/j.biocon.2025.111413](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2025.111413)
13. Fortier, R. P., Kullberg, A. T., Aragón, L., Bernal-Escobar, M., Contreras, M. P., Hurtado, C. P., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Feeley, K. J. (2025). Plant Diversity and Endemism of the Sierra Nevada De Santa Marta, Colombia, with Floristic Comparisons to Surrounding Mountains1. *Annals of the Missouri Botanical Garden*, 110(1), 71-87. [10.3417/2025921](https://doi.org/10.3417/2025921)
12. Kullberg, A. T., Aragón, L., Bernal-Escobar, M., Fortier, R., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Ballantyne, J., & Feeley, K.J. (2024). Rising temperatures will make Miami's street life even more exotic. *Urban Forestry & Urban Greening*, 128502. [10.1016/j.ufug.2024.128502](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ufug.2024.128502)
11. Kim, S., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Tarazona-Tubens, F. L., Abels, J., Lloret, M., Park, T., Malcolm-Parker, A., Galetti, M., Searcy, C. (2024). Resurrecting plant–animal interactions in the Caribbean can benefit large-fruited plants. *Restoration Ecology*, e14233. [10.1111/rec.14233](https://doi.org/10.1111/rec.14233).
10. Gonçalves, F., Farooq, H., Harfoot, M., Pires, M. M., Villar, N., Sales, L., Carvalho, C., Bello, C., Emer, C., Bovendorp, R. S., Mendes, C., Beca, G., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Souza, Y., Pedrosa, F., ... Galetti, M. (2024). A global map of species at risk of extinction due to natural hazards. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 121(26), e2321068121. [10.1073/pnas.2321068121](https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2321068121).
9. **Lautenschlager, L.**, Souza, Y., Villar, N., Galetti, M., & Feeley, K. J. (2024). Communal tapir latrines are foraging sites for tropical forest vertebrates. *Global Ecology and Conservation*, e02950. [10.1016/j.gecco.2024.e02950](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.gecco.2024.e02950).
8. **Lautenschlager, L.** & Feeley, K. (2024). Poop is cool! Animal latrines help animals and plants. *Frontiers for Young Minds journal*. 12, 1284583. [10.3389/frym.2024.1284583](https://doi.org/10.3389/frym.2024.1284583).
7. Franceschi, I. C., da Paixão Dornas, R. A., Lermen, I. S., Coelho, A. V. P., Boas, A. H. V., Chiarello, A. G., et al. (2024). Camera trap surveys of Atlantic Forest mammals: A data set for analyses considering imperfect detection (2004-2020). *Ecology*, e4298. [10.1002/ecy.4298](https://doi.org/10.1002/ecy.4298)
6. **Lautenschlager, L.**, Souza, Y., & Galetti, M. (2022). Frugivory and seed dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise *Chelonoidis carbonaria*. *Acta Oecologica*, 116, 103837. [10.1016/j.actao.2022.103837](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.actao.2022.103837).
5. Galetti, M., Gonçalves, F., Villar, N., Zipparro, V. B., Paz, C., Mendes, C., **Lautenschlager, L.**, ... Bovendorp, R. S. (2021). Causes and consequences of large-scale defaunation in the Atlantic Forest. In M. C. M. Marques & C. E. V. Grelle (Eds.), *The Atlantic Forest. History, biodiversity, threats and opportunities of the mega-diverse forest* (pp. 297-324). [10.1007/978-3-030-55322-7_14](https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-55322-7_14).
4. Mendes, C. P., Carreira, D., Pedrosa, F., Beca, G., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Akkawi, P., ... & Galetti, M. (2020). Landscape of human fear in Neotropical rainforest mammals. *Biological Conservation*, 241, 108257. [10.1016/j.biocon.2019.108257](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2019.108257).
3. Nagy-Reis, M., Oshima, J. E. D. F., Kanda, C. Z., Palmeira, F. B. L., de Melo, F. R., Morato, R. G., ... & Lopes, C. M. (2020). NEOTROPICAL CARNIVORES: a data set on carnivore distribution in the Neotropics. *Ecology*, 101(11), e03128. [10.1002/ecy.3128](https://doi.org/10.1002/ecy.3128).
2. Souza, Y., Gonçalves, F., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Akkawi, P., Mendes, C., Carvalho, M. M., ... & Galetti, M. (2019). ATLANTIC MAMMALS: a data set of assemblages of medium-and large-sized mammals of the Atlantic Forest of South America. *Ecology*, 100(10), e02785. [10.1002/ecy.2785](https://doi.org/10.1002/ecy.2785).

1. Sobral-Souza, T., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Morcatty, T. Q., Bello, C., Hansen, D., & Galetti, M. (2017). Rewilding defaunated Atlantic Forests with tortoises to restore lost seed dispersal functions. *Perspectives in ecology and conservation*, 15(4), 300-307. [10.1016/j.pecon.2017.08.005](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pecon.2017.08.005).
 - *Accepted for publication/Submitted:*
17. Galetti, M., et al. Biogeographic constraints structure ecological interaction outcomes across island ecosystems. *Science Advances*. (in review).
18. Morini, R., et al. Frugivore Taxonomic Expansion Reshapes Seed-Dispersal Networks. *Journal of Biogeography*. (in review).
19. Genes, L., et al. Rewilded lowland tapirs partially fulfill their ecological role in the Brazilian Atlantic Forest. *Journal of Applied Ecology*. (submitted).
20. Montoya, S., et al. Urbanization and seasonality shape black bear (*Ursus americanus*) foraging patterns in a fragmented Florida landscape. *Ecology and Evolution*. (submitted).

TEACHING and ACADEMIC ENGAGEMENT

▪ **Teaching Assistant**

Course: <i>General Biology Laboratory (BIL 151)</i>	2025
Instructor: Dr. Dana Krempels	
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology (University of Miami)	
Course: <i>Evolution and Biodiversity (BIL 160)</i>	2025
Instructor: Dr. Kenneth J. Feeley	
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology (University of Miami)	
Course: <i>Workshop Leaders in Biology II (BIL 382)</i>	2025
Instructor: Dr. Kenneth J. Feeley	
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology (University of Miami)	
Course: <i>General Biology Laboratory (BIL 151)</i>	2024
Instructor: Dr. Dana Krempels	
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology (University of Miami)	
Course: <i>Ecology (BIL 336)</i>	2024
Instructor: Dr. Michelle E. Afkhami	
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology (University of Miami)	
Course: <i>Introduction to Latin American and Caribbean Studies (LAS101-Q)</i>	2023
Instructor: Dr. John Twichell	
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the UMIA (University of Miami)	
Course: <i>Fieldwork Ecology</i>	2015, 2018
Instructor Dr. Mauro Galetti	
Teaching Assistant (TA) in the Department of Ecology and Biodiversity (São Paulo State University)	

▪ **Events - Organization Committee**

22 nd Tri-University Latin America and Caribbean Studies Graduate Student Conference (UM, FIU, FAU) – University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA	2024
10 th Brazilian Congress of Mastozoology, Águas de Lindóia, SP, Brazil	2019
3 rd Workshop of Ecosystem Services, São Paulo State University, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil	2015

▪ Presentation in Events

2 nd Defaunation Workshop, Center for Research on Biodiversity Dynamics and Climate Change <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Desvendando o papel ecológico da anta brasileira através de latrinas comunitárias”	2025
6 th Annual Distinguished Fellows Colloquium, Institute for Advanced Study of the Americas (UMIA) <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Dietary Ecological Roles of Lowland Tapirs in a Tropical Forest”	2024
8 th Frugivores & Seed Dispersal Symposium (FSD), Ilhéus, Bahia, Brazil <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Communal tapir latrines are foraging sites for tropical forest vertebrates”	2024
8 th Frugivores & Seed Dispersal Symposium (FSD), Ilhéus, Bahia, Brazil <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Unveiling the dietary selection of the Lowland tapir (<i>Tapirus terrestris</i>) in a tropical forest” <i>Symposia</i> : “Harnessing nucleic acids to unveil the ecology and evolution of frugivory and seed dispersal”	2024
15 th Annual Graduate Student Symposium, 15 th Annual Graduate Student Symposium <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Communal tapir latrines are foraging sites for tropical forest vertebrates”	2024
13 th International Mammalogical Congress (IMC-13), Anchorage, Alaska, USA <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Lowland Tapir latrines as an alternative food source for vertebrates in the Atlantic Forest”	2023
14 th Annual Graduate Student Symposium, Department of Biology, University of Miami <i>Poster presentation</i> : “Lowland Tapir latrines as an alternative food source for vertebrates in the Atlantic Forest”	2023
Friday Seminar – Biology Graduate Program, Department of Biology, University of Miami <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Dietary ecological functioning of ungulates in a tropical forest”	2021
12 th Annual Graduate Student Symposium, Department of Biology, University of Miami <i>Poster presentation</i> : “Biogeography of mutualistic interactions in island ecosystems”	2021
10 th Brazilian Congress of Mastozoology, Águas de Lindóia, SP, Brazil <i>Oral presentation</i> : “Effects of domestic megafauna and landscape on the diversity of mammals in the Atlantic Forest remnants”	2019
6 th Theoretical Ecology Symposium, University of Campinas (UNICAMP), Campinas, SP, Brazil <i>Poster presentation</i> : “Frugivory and Seed Dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise (<i>Chelonoidis carbonaria</i>)”	2018

OUTREACH INITIATIVES

<i>BioReach – Department of Biology Outreach Program</i> – University of Miami Volunteer to teach students about biological concepts at Ponce de León Middle School, Miami, FL, USA	2023
<i>Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)</i> – United Nations, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Volunteer during the event “Knowing the 17 Sustainable Development Goals of the United Nations”	2019
<i>Academic Preparation Course– ATHO</i> , São Paulo State University, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil Contributed to integrating underprivileged communities through a preparatory course at São Paulo State University, focusing on equipping young adults and adults for admission to Brazilian public universities. Responsibilities included teaching English classes, organizing educational events, and actively participating in the organizing committee.	2011- 2015

▪ Non-Governmental Organization Internship

Karumbé – Centro de Tortugas Marinas, La Coronilla, Uruguay **2014**

Collaborated with the NGO “Karumbé” in sea turtle research and conservation within Cerro Verde’s protected marine area, Uruguay. Activities included beach monitoring, animal sightings, capture, tagging, rehabilitation, and release.

▪ Fieldwork Assistant

Dr. Michaela Peterson – Vanderbilt University, USA **2019**

Monitored white-lipped peccaries through camera trapping and their tracks in the Atlantic Forest in Brazil.

Dr. Vincent Fehr – Aarhus University, Denmark **2018**

Studied exotic palms and their potential for invasion in the Atlantic Forest in Brazil.

MSc. Thomas Paul Arkwright – University of Copenhagen, Denmark **2017**

Studied the maned wolf population in the Brazilian savanna (Cerrado biome).



RESEARCH FUNDING and INTERNATIONAL AWARDS

Dean’s Summer Research Fellowship – University of Miami **2024**

Title: “Nutrient Fertilization and Plant Recruitment by the Lowland Tapir (*Tapirus terrestris*)”

Amount: USD 5,000

Summer Doctoral Research Grant – Graduate School – University of Miami **2024**

Title: “Nutrient Fertilization and Plant Recruitment by the Lowland Tapir (*T. terrestris*) in a Tropical Forest”

Amount: USD 5,000

Kushlan Graduate Research Support Award – Department of Biology, University of Miami **2024**

Title: “Nutrient fertilization and plant recruitment by the Lowland Tapir (*Tapirus terrestris*)”

Amount: USD 800.00

Lewis and Clark Fund for Exploration and Field Research **2023**

Title: “Dietary Ecological Functioning of Large Mammalian Herbivores in a Tropical Forest”

Amount: USD 4,900

Latin American Student Field Research Award (American Society of Mammalogists – ASM) **2023**

Title: “Dietary Ecological Functioning of Large Mammalian Herbivores in a Tropical Forest”

Amount: USD 1,500

Kushlan Graduate Research Support Award – Department of Biology, University of Miami **2023**

Title: “Comparing Dietary Ecological Functions of Herbivores in a Tropical Forest”

Amount: USD 500.00

CNPq - Brazilian National Council for Scientific and Technological Development (# 405839/2021-9) **21–2023**

Title: “Defaunation Effects on the Ecological Functions of Plant Communities in Tropical Forests”

Amount: R\$ 82,500 (USD 16,500 approx.)

▪ Fellowships

UMIA/LAS Distinguished Graduate Fellows Program (Ph.D.) **2023 – 2024**

PI: Dr. Kenneth Feeley

Amount: USD 30,000

Aldridge Graduate Scholarship in Tropical Biology (Ph.D.) **2021– 2023**

PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti

Amount: USD 24,950

<i>CAPES (Coordination for the Improvement of Higher Education Personnel (MS)</i>	2017 – 2019
PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti	
Amount: R\$ 36,000	
<i>CNPQ (National Council for Scientific and Technological Development) (BS)</i>	2012 – 2016
PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti	
Amount: R\$ 4,800	
